

01 The FDE Playbook

What a Forward Deployed Engineer is, *and how to hire one.*

01 What a Forward Deployed Engineer actually is

A Forward Deployed Engineer is not a consultant who hands off a deck, and not a contractor who takes tickets. An FDE owns a business problem end to end: discovery, architecture, production code, hardening, and the handoff that lets the client's own team run the system without them.

The role exists because most hard problems inside a company are not "we need an engineer" or "we need a strategist" in isolation. They are ambiguous, cross-functional, and often regulatory or operational in nature, and they need someone who can sit with the people living the problem, turn what they describe into a real build plan, and then personally ship it.

02 The FDE method: five moves

Every engagement runs the same loop, regardless of industry or stack.

SCOPE

Turn a symptom into a build plan.

Sit with the business partner who describes a symptom, not a system. Pull out what they actually need, decomposed into a real build plan, in the room.

PROTOTYPE

Build it fast.

Build the whole stack, data layer, backend, UI, and any AI components, using AI-assisted development. Working software in days and weeks, not quarters.

HARDEN

Make it production-grade.

Eval suites with pass thresholds, guardrails, structured logging, audit trails, rollback, and access control verified with negative tests. This is the phase regulated and rights-sensitive shops probe hardest.

HAND OFF

Ship it so the team owns it.

Every build ships with a handoff package, README, runbook, architecture decision records, plus a pairing session so the receiving team stays self-sufficient after the FDE leaves.

HARVEST

Push the pattern back into the platform.

After each build, the reusable patterns go into a shared library so the next engagement starts further along. Every system compounds into the next.

03 Signs you need one

The problem is described in symptoms, not requirements, and the people closest to it cannot yet say what "done" looks like.

It spans multiple systems, teams, or functions, data, operations, and compliance all touch it, and no single existing owner has authority across all three.

There is real regulatory or operational exposure, so "move fast and see what breaks" is not an acceptable strategy.

You need someone who can both make the architectural call and personally write the production code, not hand off a recommendation and wait.

A prior AI pilot or proof of concept stalled before reaching production, because the gap between demo and deployable system was wider than expected.

04 What good looks like

REGULATED AI · TITLE IV · LIVE

Higher Ed Compliance Software

A compliance team at a regulated Title IV student-aid provider was buried in rules and manual checks. A multi-agent platform on Claude, LangGraph, and MCP took it from first discovery call through launch and handoff. It runs today inside a federally regulated environment.

\$2.7M in new revenue in the first three months on a \$1.7M base, and 25% more case-processing capacity with no new hires.

[Read the case study →](#)

ENTERPRISE SCALE · CREATIVE OPERATIONS

Walmart, a data org built from scratch

Creative Operations had plenty of data and no way to trust it. Bottlenecks became clean models and tools leaders could actually decide with, and a data organization was built to keep it running at Walmart's scale.

37% improvement in project completion rates across the division.

[Read the case study →](#)

FOUNDER · REVUITY SYSTEMS

Revuity Agentic OS

Built to prove the method holds with no big organization behind it. The Agentic OS is the machinery that makes agentic delivery repeatable.

\$250K+ in SaaS savings, plus a 15% lift in sales and marketing performance.

[Read the case study →](#)

05 How to evaluate and hire one

Ask for evidence of full-lifecycle ownership, not just architecture opinions. A real FDE can point to systems they scoped, built, hardened, and handed off, with the client team running it after they left.

Screen for production code, not just prototypes. The hard part of AI-assisted development is rarely the demo, it is the eval suite, the guardrails, the audit logging, and the negative tests that make a system trustworthy in a regulated or high-stakes environment.

Check the handoff discipline specifically. Ask what happens the day the FDE leaves. If the answer is vague, the engagement will create a dependency instead of a capability.

Match the engagement model to how clear the problem is. A fixed-scope diagnostic sprint fits an unclear problem; a retainer fits ongoing senior judgment; embedded execution fits a mandate to ship, not just advise.

06 Working with Jay

Jay Burgess is a Principal Forward Deployed Engineer and the founder of Revuity Systems, with 15+ years turning ambiguous operational and regulatory problems into production systems, 17+ shipped, including a compliance platform that generated \$2.7M in new revenue in its first three months.

Engagements run as a diagnostic sprint, a fractional architecture retainer, or embedded build ownership, depending on how clear the problem already is. Full details, including published rate ranges, are on the engagement page.